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The Arab Body as an Afterthought

Albert Camus' 'The Plague' is a celebrated absurdist novel about the occurrences surrounding a plague in a small, costal town. The question of postcolonialism is made possible due to its setting in the fictionalised town of Oran – in reality the second-largest port city of Algeria – during the period of French colonization, and Camus' own upbringing as a second-generation French inhabitant of Algeria. Edward Said, in 'Culture and Imperialism' posits that a postcolonial reading of 'The Plague' only leaves the reader bereft: he charges Camus as being blind to the colonial predicament he grew up in, highlighted in the complete erasure of the native Arab presence within the text. One could argue, on the other hand, that this blindness shows itself as the failure of language within the text, signalling an inability to express, in the language of the colonizer, the omnipotent force of imperialism hanging over the heads of the characters: every attempt at an utterance in the space of 'The Plague' is an idiom corrupted by colonization.

At the outset, I must assert that any analysis of 'The Plague' as a postcolonial text is an analysis of negation: we read for what is not there. Like the plague itself, the postcolonial reading is undefined and unreified – we read through the symptoms that gradually pervade and overtake the text. For Said's reading of Camus as a failed postcolonialist, this negation is that of Arab voices and Arab death; for a reading of Camus as anticipating an impending postcolonialism, the negation is that of the symbolic order of language. In the next two sections of the essay, I will attempt to offer a measured representation of these two views; in the last section, I will trace a singular insight from the text that, I believe, offers a way of

seeing Camus, outside of these two views of negation but ultimately trapped in the colonial gaze.

A Failed Postcolonialism

In Chapter 7 of 'Culture and Imperialism', *Camus and the French Imperial Experience*, Said deconstructs Camus' novels in search for the colonized object, and finds only "a waste and sadness" (185) where it is obscured by "a superstructure" (181) of French superiority. The ordering of space and the very "structure of civil society" in the novel is so undeniably French that it invisibilizes the Arab (Said 181), and this erasure of Arabs is an erasure of colonial Algeria itself. So deeply are the natives looked over that "their presence seems like a barely evident natural fact" (Said 176) – in fact, if desired, one could (with ease) convince themselves no Arabs had died in 'The Plague', given the dearth of any proof to the contrary or even any reference to them.

The decorated connection of "the French empire […] to the French national identity," (Said 171) is put on display for the reader in the very first instance of the novel, where it asserts Oran as a "French port" only geographically "on the Algerian Coast" (Camus 3). In the same way France reproduces itself in Algeria, Camus reproduces colonial narratives by reducing this colonized land and people to its relation with the Empire. Indeed, readings of the novel that celebrate its timelessness in the exploration of the universal human condition are committing the gross mistake of "interpretatively blocking off what Camus blocked off about Algeria" (Said 178).

In the novel, the cruelty is that "Arabs die of plague in Oran, but they are not named" (Said 175). The gravitas of this misstep, to Said, is in the fact that this erasure is reproduced in academic and cultural discourse around Camus' works. The totalizing French gaze that erases Arab presence (even in death) is delicately valorized and then dismissed as "representative of the Western consciousness and conscience in relation to the non-Western

world" (O'Brien, as in Said 173). This term, "Western consciousness", has essentially nothing to do with colonization: it has no bearing on the daily lived experiences of the Arabs, the large-scale economic and political exploitation they face, or the violence they are subjected to. As Said puts it, the term is just "a receptacle emptied of all but its capacity for sentience and reflection" (174); the method of discussing Camus' works in wider contexts only further depoliticises, dehistoricises and distances itself from the force and cruelty of colonization, and the burdens of "slavery, land expropriation and murderous armed forces" (173-174) thrust upon the Arab people.

Anticipating Postcolonialism

On the other hand, I concede that Said's reading of Camus does not necessarily look past the erasure of Arab deaths to ask whether anything else takes its place. Camus' positionality as part of a settler class in Algeria make his inability to *see* Algeria "unacceptably paralyzing" (185) to Said; but it is this very inescapable positionality, simultaneously belonging and being Othered from both France and Algeria, that lends itself to the splitting, mirroring and doubling back of the connection between the French empire and its colonies that Said refers to. Ensnared in this web, Camus has little in the way of an articulation. With this negation of language, we should ask if this narrative *could* have any other mode of reification.

Through the novel, Camus uses the plague and its necessitated isolation to create space for himself between the Empire and the colony he is bound to: he distances Oran from the totalizing dominance of the Empire using the metaphor of the quarantine. The quarantine creates a "zone of indeterminacy" (Roy 2) that allows for a dismantling of the imperial imposition onto the landscape of the Algerian coast. Camus then explores how people order themselves in a newfound space where the structures of the imperial system become undone, and it is this reordering that realises the limits of language in 'The Plague'. Simply put, he

shows us that there are no words in the language of the colonizer to address the restructuring of a space that has been marked by colonization.

This impoverishment of language finds itself in the attempt to communicate. This attempt is doubled in the space of Oran: first, in the sending of the word, because letters were banned and telegrams had the constraint of ten words, and then second, in the writing of the word itself. The townspeople, restrained in this way, keep revising their words in an attempt to express their predicament, but despite their dwelling, the "living words, into which [they] had as it were transfused [their] hearts' blood, were drained of any meaning" (Camus 65). Language thus fails in expression, but the imagination, which has its detour in desire and love, restores the townspeople's memory: demonstrated in the habits of Rambert, who imagines the street of Paris and his lover in lieu of sleeping (Camus 103-104). However, in the case of Joseph Grand, who is exemplified as the impoverishment of language, the imagination, too, fails. He repeatedly rewrites a single line that depicts the image of a stately woman on horseback in a Parisian avenue – an imagined scene that betrays the "yearning for a lost and never experienced power of Europe" (Roy 4). The constant revisiting and revision of this sentence, in a postcolonial reading, can become a placeholder for an eventual postcolonial voice (Roy).

Violence of an Afterthought

To summarize, I have shown that reading the negations in 'The Plague' offer two postcolonial critiques: first, through Said, a failure to perceive Arab voice and hence Algeria itself, and second, a failure in deploying language that is symptomatic of the postcolonial desire. At the closure of this essay, I want to offer a single instance from the text that might undercut the reading of the 'negation' I have pivoted the readings on – in this interaction, we can just barely glimpse the shape of the colonized subject, pushed into the margins of the narrative. I posit that it is through this singular glimpse that the painful force of Camus'

colonial gaze presents itself as guilty of Said's charges, and further incompatible with a postcolonial reading.

In a short chapter a few weeks into the quarantine of Oran, Grand recounts to Rieux some interactions he has observed of Cottard with other townspeople:

> Grand had personally witnessed an odd scene that took place at the tobacconist's. An animated conversation was in progress and the woman behind the counter started airing her views about a murder case that had created some stir in Algiers. A young commercial employee had killed an Algerian on a beach.
>
> "I always say," the woman began, "if they clapped all that scum in jail, decent folks could breathe more freely."
>
> She was too much startled by Cottard's reaction—he dashed out of the shop without a word of excuse—to continue. Grand and the woman gazed after him, dumbfounded (52-53).

The violence of this interaction is notable precisely because in comparison to the rest of the novel – with its descriptions of bleeding people stumbling in the streets (49), desperate patients and their screaming families (85), the piles of corpses pushed into a pit (167) caused by a metaphysical plague – the image of a human violence that enacts violence on another human and takes its life is devoid of any grotesqueness. Its detail, too, never exceeds this excerpt: we do not know why the murder took place, the portraits of the people – not even so much as a pronoun is spared on the murderer and the victim. We do not even know if the employee was Algerian, but in any case, the Algerian identity of the victim does not offer much insight, either: recall that Camus himself is both French and Algerian.

To immediately assume either of these two characters is French is to be complicit in the French superstructure that Said says Camus has imposed on Algeria. Let me make a case for the hypothetical that the murderer was Arab (or, if you prefer the less strong argument, that they were a member of a native, colonized class). The word "scum" would not be so easily assigned to a French person, certainly not in the presence of two Frenchmen. The

contrasting term “decent folk” has a shared quality to it that goes beyond a repudiation of morality – as if saying *they*, the French people in the shop, are the decent folk. And lastly, the “dumbfounded” looks betray a confusion as to why such a statement (which is controversial only outside the white gaze) could garner Cottard’s extreme reaction.

If we are willing to consider this, then it follows that we must also consider that Said’s conclusion that Camus was blind to the Arab presence is wrong – Camus slips on the more serious count of forgetfulness. To be blind to something is to have no sight of it; but to forget something is to have sight of it only to lose it, to relegate it to an afterthought. Camus is not unable to see the Arabs, he sees and *passes over* them, he explicitly refuses them a space in his totalizing narrative. Said’s claim that Camus reproduces colonial narratives within the text of ‘The Plague’ hence strengthens its accusation on my interpretation.

On the other hand, the second reading in which the attempt by Camus, via the reworking of language to compensate for the lack of language to address the postcolonial, to ‘create’ a space for the postcolonial voice is not only unnecessary, but also a failure. The short, unaddressed burst of this interaction marginalized within the narrative paired with Cottard’s strange and quick exit may be regarded, under the scope of this analysis, as another instance of Camus being unable to conceive of a postcolonial voice – in other words, this excerpt is just another failure of language. But to commit to this would be to reject the colonized figure’s agency: the embodiment in violence (recall Fanon) is an assertion of a postcolonial space in and of itself. Camus’ negation of language is only the precondition for the postcolonial space, but the Arab voice and Arab desire has already forayed into postcolonialism.

Camus’ tendency to postcolonialism in ‘The Plague’ then, falls into an afterthought on this account too – Camus sees the threat to colonization, and passes over it. ‘The Plague’ reproduces the colonial narrative for Said due to its rejection of Arab bodies in death. The

postcolonial narrative redeems the text by assigning it the role of an anticipatory postcolonialism read in its unsatisfying returns and silences to language structures. But the presence of the live Arab body, that with no narration and only embodiment, fails to grant Camus a postcolonial position – simply because it exists and precisely because its existence is an afterthought.

References

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